picture of the universe at a given moment contains exactly the same events; everyone's *now* is the same *now,* and so everyone's now-list for a given moment is identical. If someone or something is on your now-list for a given moment, then it is necessarily also on my now-list for that moment. Most people's intuition is still bound up with this way of thinking, but special relativity tells a very different story. Look again at Figure 3.4. Two observers in relative motion have *nows*—single moments in time, from each one's perspective—that are different: their *nows* slice through spacetime at different angles. And different *nows* mean different now-lists. *Observers moving relative to each other have different conceptions of what exists at a given moment, and hence they have different conceptions of reality.*

At everyday speeds, the angle between two observers' now-slices is minuscule; that's why in day-to-day life we never notice a discrepancy between our definition of *now* and anybody else's. For this reason, most discussions of special relativity focus on what would happen if we traveled at enormous speeds—speeds near that of light—since such motion would tremendously magnify the effects. But there is another way to magnify the distinction between two observers' conceptions of *now,* and I find that it provides a particularly enlightening approach to the question of reality. It is based on the following simple fact: if you and I slice up an ordinary loaf at slightly different angles, it will have hardly any effect on the resulting pieces of bread. But if the loaf is *huge,* the conclusion is different. Just as a tiny opening between the blades of an enormously long pair of scissors translates into a large separation between the blade tips, cutting an enormous loaf of bread at slightly different angles yields slices that deviate by a huge amount at distances far from where the slices cross. You can see this in Figure 5.2.

The same is true for spacetime. At everyday speeds, the slices depicting *now* for two observers in relative motion will be oriented at only slightly different angles. If the two observers are nearby, this will have hardly any effect. But, just as in the loaf of bread, tiny angles generate large separations between slices when their impact is examined over large distances. And for slices of spacetime, a large deviation between slices means a significant disagreement on which events each observer considers to be happening now. This is illustrated in Figures 5.3 and 5.4, and it implies that individuals moving relative to each other,